

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS



INDIA - BANGLADESH - 2

MODULE - 19

- In the recent years, a feeling of scepticism towards India is brewing among the people of Bangladesh.
- It is owed to the following factors

POLITICAL

1 The National Register of Citizens (NRC) has raised serious concerns in Bangladesh as it is seen as an exercise to identify illegal migrants from Bangladesh to India.

2 In Assam, around 1.9 million people have been excluded from the list and Bangladesh fears that all those people might be deported

3 On the side-lines of the 74th UN General Assembly, India assured Bangladesh not to worry about the NRC



SECURITY

i ILLEGAL IMMIGRATION

- 1 Illegal immigration is a problem for India. The most affected states are West Bengal, Assam, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Bihar and Tripura.
- 2 These immigrants have not only changed the demography and disturbed the ecology of north-east but have been encouraged them to exercise their political rights in India as citizens.
- 3 This is deeply impacting the communal, political, social and economic tensions and conflicts in north-eastern India.
- 4 The Supreme Court has asked Centre to complete fencing of border to check infiltration into Assam.
- 5 The issue of illegal migration has acquired greater attention with the publication of the draft National Register of Citizens in Assam.



SECURITY

ii ROHINGYA ISSUE

- 1 The Rohingya issue has imposed a huge economic and security burden on Bangladesh.
- 2 According to government reports, there are more than 1.1 million Rohingya Muslims in Bangladesh.
- 3 India has supplied humanitarian aid to Bangladesh under 'Operation Insaniyat' for Rohingya crisis but Bangladesh expects India to put pressure on Myanmar for repatriation of over a million of Rohingyas



SECURITY

iii

ILLEGAL TRADE

- 1 The Indo-Bangla border is a route for smuggling livestock, food items, medicines and drugs from India to Bangladesh.
- 2 There are occasional skirmishes along the border between the Border Security Guards of India and Bangladesh.
- 3 Cattle smuggling is an issue. Cattle haats are a source of smuggling.

- 4 Fake dumping of currency notes is also evident along the border areas.



ECONOMIC

i

TRADE

- Bangladesh is a major trading partner of India.

1 Trade deficit for Bangladesh is more than \$4 billion.

2 However, Bangladesh is urging to remove all non-tariff barriers as it views them as major obstacles to growth.

3 Bangladeshi exports to India have not increased in India because of lack of demand in India and limited items of Bangladeshi export.

4 India provided a credit line of \$1 billion to Bangladesh for the development of infrastructure projects but imposed strict conditions on it including 85 percent of the raw materials for the project to be purchased from India.



ECONOMIC

ii

TRANSIT

- In 1972, both sides agreed on a mutually beneficial arrangement for the use of their waterways, railways and roadways for commerce. But it is yet to be operational.



SHARING OF RIVER WATER

- India and Bangladesh share 54 trans-boundary rivers.
- Federal political dynamics prevented India to resolve the issue of river water sharing amicably.

i

FARAKKA BARRAGE

- 1 In 1996, the sharing of the Ganga waters was successfully agreed upon between the two nations.
- 2 The major area of dispute has been India's construction and operation of the Farakka Barrage.
- 3 The aim of construction of the Farakka Barrage was to increase the lean period flow of the Bhagirathi-Hooghly branch of Ganga to increase the water depth at the Kolkata port which was threatened by the situation.



SHARING OF RIVER WATER

ISSUE

- The inadequacy to meet the demands in the two countries is the root cause of the conflict.
- Bangladesh feels that the reduction in flow caused damage to agriculture, industry and ecology in the basin in Bangladesh.



SHARING OF RIVER WATER

ii

TEESTA WATER DISPUTE

- 1 Teesta river has its source in Sikkim. It flows through the northern part of West Bengal in India before entering Bangladesh.
- 2 In 1983, an ad-hoc water sharing agreement was reached between India and Bangladesh allocating 39% and 36% water flow respectively.
- 3 The new bilateral treaty proposed distributing equal amount between the two countries.
- 4 This was rejected by the Chief Minister of West Bengal fearing loss of water during the lean season.
- 5 A new agreement for the river water sharing is pending since 2011.



SHARING OF RIVER WATER

iii CONSTRUCTION OF TIPAIMUKH DAM

- 1 Tipaimukh dam is a hydel power project proposed on river Barak in Manipur
- 2 Bangladesh feels that the construction of this dam would seriously affect its Sylhet district and its agriculture, fisheries and ecology.
- 3 Bangladesh is wary of India's high-handedness and fears construction of this dam would be an example.

There is a huge potential in Inland navigation through rivers of both countries.



GEOPOLITICAL

i NEW MOORE ISLAND

- 1 The New Moore Island has a critical importance to both India and Bangladesh. The island has been a bone of contention since 1970.
- 2 In 1974, India established its ownership over the island. In 1978 Bangladesh questioned India's claim over the island.
- 3 In order to settle the dispute, Bangladesh proposed sending a joint Indo-Bangladesh team to determine the flow of channels based on International Law of Sea.
- 4 In 2014, UN Tribunal's award has also recognized India's sovereignty over New Moore island.



GEOPOLITICAL

ii

EEZ

1 Delimitation of sea boundary and determining Bangladesh's exclusive economic zone has always remained unresolved.

2 The presence of Andaman and Nicobar Islands puts India in an advantageous position.



CHINA FACTOR

- 1 Bangladesh and China have decade-long diplomatic relationship. 2015 marked the 40th year of their relationship.
- 2 China is financing 25 energy projects in Bangladesh and has extended its support to build Bangladesh Second Nuclear power plant.
- 3 China's new initiatives for setting up financial institutions like Asian Infrastructure Development bank (AIIB) is likely to create opportunities for Bangladesh in assessing funds for infrastructure development.



CHINA FACTOR

- 4 China's role in the development of Chittagong is particularly worrisome for India. India feels these ports would encircle and gain other opening to the sea.
- 5 In 2008, Bangladesh set up a missile launch pad near Chittagong port with assistance from China.
- 6 China helped Bangladesh develop Bangabandhu-1 First communication satellite.



RECENT STATE VISITS

i

2015

- 1 PM Modi's visited Bangladesh in 2015, and a joint declaration titled 'Notun Projonmo-Nayi Disha' was signed.
- 2 22 agreements were signed under it relating to connectivity, grid connection, generation of power, improving balance of trade, better coordination among the border guarding forces and people-to-people contact.
- 3 India and Bangladesh have border haats and there are proposals to increase them.
- 4 They agreed to establish two new Special Economic Zones in Mongla and Bheramara, which is likely to generate employment, cater to the markets of Bangladesh and India and contribute to correcting balance of trade.



ii 2017

RECENT STATE VISITS

- 1 PM Hasina's visit to India and the Government of India and Bangladesh organized the Sommonona programme
- 2 It was a gesture from Bangladesh in recognising the supreme sacrifices made by 1,661 Indian martyrs for the liberation of Bangladesh.
- 3 It was for the first time that a country recognised the contribution of another country by honouring the martyrs at their motherland.
- 4 During the Summit meetings in 2017, the two Prime Ministers elevated the relationship to the level of 'Strategic Partnership'.
- 5 During this visit, 11 Agreements and 24 MOUs were signed covering security, trade, connectivity, energy, civil nuclear agreement, defence, introduction of bus and train service etc.



iii

OCTOBER 2019

RECENT STATE VISITS

- Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina visited India in October 2019.
- It provides a future roadmap for India-Bangladesh relations.

SECURITY

- 1 Both leaders directed their respective border forces to complete border fencing at all pending sectors at the International Border
- 2 MoU for providing a Coastal Surveillance System was signed
- 3 India extended US\$ 500 mn Defence Line of Credit to Bangladesh in April 2019.



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OCTOBER 2019

RECENT STATE VISITS

ECONOMIC

- 1 Both sides agreed to work towards a bilateral Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) between India and Bangladesh.
- 2 Border haats have had a positive impact on the people living along the border areas and the leaders decided establishment of twelve Border Haats
- 3 Promote collaboration between the textiles and jute sectors of both the countries through an MOU



RECENT STATE VISITS

TRADE

- 1 MoU between Bangladesh Standards and Testing Institution (BSTI) and Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) was renewed to help facilitate enhanced trade in goods between the two countries in a balanced manner.
- 2 The leaders acknowledged exports from Bangladesh to India crossed the one billion dollar mark in 2019
- 3 Bangladesh agreed to India's requests to remove port restrictions on most items of regular trade being traded through Akhaura-Agartala port



RECENT STATE VISITS

TRANSIT

- 1 The leaders welcomed the decision to operationalize the Dhulian-Gadagari-Rajshahi-Daulatdia-Aricha Route (to and fro) and include Daudkandi-Sonamura Route (to and fro) under Protocol on Inland Water Transit and Trade.
- 2 Standard Operating Procedures for the use of Chattogram and Mongla ports for movement of goods to and from India, particularly to and from the North East of India, was concluded.
- 3 To facilitate better connectivity and simplify movement of passengers and goods, the leaders agreed to early operationalization of the BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement for movement of goods and passengers.



INDIA'S FUTURE INTERESTS

- 4 It is also a land bridge to East Asia and the future of a Bay of Bengal community.
- 5 Expanding security cooperation with India could enhance Bangladesh's global leverage.
- 6 For India, a strong partnership with Bangladesh will help boost the prospects of peace and security in the eastern subcontinent.
- 7 For India to develop its restive northeast, it will be essential to strengthen its broader regional security paradigm.



INDIA'S FUTURE INTERESTS

8 Transit would not only increase connectivity, but also offer opportunities for regional connectivity and help Bangladesh develop Chittagong port into a regional hub.

9 The mutual transit will also give Bangladesh a much shorter route to China and an initiative to link Chinese province of Yunnan with seven sisters.

10 But the anti-Indian elements inside Bangladesh are holding the agreement of transit with India.

11 India is wanting to develop the Payra port in Bangladesh which will help reduce the traffic in Chittagong. This can provide better accessibility to the north-east.



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